instrumental in nabbing India’s most dreaded terrorist, Harjinder Singh Jinda.

As Anirudhya stopped typing and dialled the pantry for tea, he noticed that the only question doing the rounds was who killed Rajiv Gandhi in the middle of the country’s general elections. Was it an insider job to create sympathy in favour of his party and pull up its dwindling popularity? It was too soon to respond to any such speculation.

Anirudhya telephoned Verma on his direct line. Unexpectedly, his secretary responded. Verma had asked Anirudhya to see him later. There was no clarity on when and where, though. But it didn’t take long for them to catch up over a quick coffee at Khan Market. Verma took him through what had happened in the wee hours of 22 May.

Verma, Vijay Karan’s executive assistant and a Tamil Nadu-cadre 1986-batch IPS officer, was waiting to throw his hand into the ring. But he knew that being Karan’s chief assistant, he couldn’t just opt for another assignment. Also, the names had been cleared by the PMO. Seeing Karan look tired on their way back to office in the same car, Verma asked how the Cabinet committee meeting in the wee hours had gone. Karan told him the R&AW didn’t think that the LTTE had a hand in the assassination. Verma instantly countered, ‘They know nothing, sir. It’s the LTTE.’ The chief, slightly miffed, wanted to know what made him so sure. Verma started his batting. He said he was not ‘sure’ but backed it with a counter-question. Who else would dare to choose the soil of Tamil Nadu for such an action? Most likely the neighbour. The LTTE had turned Tamil Nadu into a hideout, courtesy of a friendly government, political allies and sympathizers. The strategy of the LTTE, Verma thought, was to ‘kill someone in Sri Lanka and then escape to India’ or ‘kill someone in India and then escape to Sri Lanka’. It would take not more than a few hours.

Karan saw his argument but felt it was too early to jump to any such conclusion. He stressed the argument based on the track record of the LTTE. They were far more brutal than even the Colombian mercenaries who worked for the drug lord Escobar. The LTTE guerrillas took no less than fifty lives in every attack, sometimes over 100. Many Tamil rebels